

● CHECKLIST · 115 ITEMS · 5 PHASES

The Startup *Marketing* Checklist

Everything a seed to Series A team should have in place, in the order it should happen. Built from launches across Web3, AI and cybersecurity, where trust is the product and a sloppy foundation costs you the first impression you only get once.

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

1. Work top to bottom. Phase 1 is not optional: every later phase leaks without it.
2. Assign one owner per unchecked item. "The team" is not an owner.
3. Grey text under an item is the reason it matters. If the reason does not apply to you, skip it on purpose and write down why.
4. Revisit the Always-on page every Monday. That page is the job once the launch is over.

BEST FOR

Founders and first marketing hires, pre-seed to Series A

TIME TO COMPLETE

Phase 1: two to three weeks part-time.
Phases 2 to 4: about 4 months

COMPANION

20 Marketing Channels Playbook and the interactive checklist at shilikajain.com/tools

PHASE 1

Foundations

Positioning, measurement and email infrastructure. Unglamorous, and the single biggest reason paid and earned channels underperform for young companies.

POSITIONING AND ICP

- ☐ Write a one-sentence ICP: company type, stage or size, the trigger event that makes them buy now, and the buyer's title.
If you cannot name the trigger event, you will spend on people who agree with you but never buy.
- ☐ List 10 named accounts that fit the ICP and 3 that look close but are not a fit.
The near-misses sharpen your disqualifiers faster than any persona doc.
- ☐ Interview at least 10 target buyers before writing copy. Record their exact words for the problem.
- ☐ Name the real alternative you replace: a spreadsheet, an incumbent, an in-house build, an agency, or doing nothing.
- ☐ Write a positioning statement (use the ICP and Positioning Worksheet) and read it to 5 people outside the company.
- ☐ Choose a category buyers already search for, then sharpen it with a qualifier. Avoid inventing a category unless you have the budget to educate a market.
- ☐ List 3 proof points you can show today: a live demo, an audit, a design partner quote, a usage number you are comfortable publishing.

MESSAGING

- ☐ Homepage headline says what it is and who it is for in 12 words or fewer.
- ☐ Write the one-liner, the 50-word and the 150-word description. Store them in one shared doc that everyone copies from.
- ☐ Build a messaging hierarchy: one core claim, three pillars, one proof per pillar.
- ☐ Write answers to your top 5 objections ("we already use X", "is it secure", "too early for us").
- ☐ Write the founder story in under 120 words: why this team, why now.
- ☐ Agree a banned-words list (vague superlatives, hype terms, claims you cannot prove).
Security and AI buyers discount hype instantly. Crypto audiences have seen every superlative.

WEBSITE AND BRAND

- ☐ Logo in SVG and PNG, light and dark versions, plus a square avatar for social.
- ☐ Mobile Largest Contentful Paint under 2.5 seconds on your homepage and top landing page.
- ☐ Every page has a unique title, meta description, canonical URL and Open Graph image.
- ☐ One primary call to action per page (demo, waitlist, docs, install). Not three.
- ☐ About page with real names, photos and links to LinkedIn or X.
Anonymous teams lose journalists, enterprise buyers and AI search engines in that order.

- ☐ A pricing page, or a "how pricing works" page, even if it ends with "talk to us".
- ☐ A technical page (docs, architecture, security overview) for the engineer who gets forwarded your link.
- ☐ Organization schema with sameAs links to every official profile.

ANALYTICS AND ATTRIBUTION

- ☐ Analytics installed and verified with a test visit (GA4, Plausible or PostHog).
- ☐ Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools verified, XML sitemap submitted to both.
- ☐ Conversion events defined and firing: signup, demo request, waitlist join, docs visit, install.
- ☐ UTM naming convention written down: lowercase, source = platform, medium = channel type, campaign = initiative.
- ☐ "How did you hear about us?" free-text field on signup or demo forms.
Self-reported attribution catches podcasts, communities and AI answers that click tracking misses.
- ☐ CRM set up with lifecycle stages (lead, qualified, opportunity, customer) and one owner.
- ☐ One weekly dashboard with no more than 5 numbers.

DOMAIN AND EMAIL AUTHENTICATION

- ☐ Separate sending domain (for example `getyourco.com`) for any cold outbound. Never cold email from your primary domain.
- ☐ SPF record published on every sending domain, listing only the services that actually send for you. Stay under the 10 DNS lookup limit.
- ☐ DKIM signing enabled for each sender: Google Workspace or Microsoft 365, your email platform, your CRM, your support desk.
- ☐ DMARC record published at `p=none` with a rua reporting address.
- ☐ DMARC reports reviewed for 2 to 4 weeks, then policy moved to quarantine, then reject once all legitimate senders pass.
- ☐ Custom tracking and link domain set up in your email platform.
- ☐ New inboxes and domains warmed for 2 to 4 weeks before any volume. Low daily caps per inbox.
- ☐ Google Postmaster Tools verified so you can see domain reputation and spam rate.
- ☐ One-click unsubscribe header enabled on marketing email (required by major mailbox providers for bulk senders).
- ☐ Registrar account protected with 2FA. Obvious typo domains and your handles on X, LinkedIn, GitHub, Discord, Telegram and YouTube reserved.
Impersonation and phishing hit Web3 and security brands first, often during launch week.

LEGAL AND COMPLIANCE

- ☐ Privacy policy and cookie notice that match what your analytics and pixels actually collect.

- ☐ Terms of service published.
- ☐ Trademark clearance search on the company and product name. File in core markets when budget allows.
- ☐ Marketing claims review. No unqualified "unhackable", "fully secure", "guaranteed" or "audited" without the audit link.
- ☐ Token or financial products: legal review of all copy that touches returns, price, listings or eligibility, plus geo-restrictions on campaigns where required.
- ☐ Email consent recorded. Double opt-in for EU and UK subscribers.
- ☐ Written permission on file for every customer logo, quote and case study.

Phase 1 exit test. A stranger can read your homepage and say who it is for, what it replaces and why to believe you. A test signup shows up in your CRM with a source. Your domain passes SPF, DKIM and DMARC on a mail-tester check. If any of the three fail, do not start Phase 2.

PHASE 2 Pre-launch (*T-8 to T-1 weeks*)

The launch is decided here, not on launch day. Most of the coverage, signups and community energy you see in week one was set up in these eight weeks.

PLAN

- ☐ Launch date chosen and checked against major industry conferences, holidays and known big announcements in your space.
- ☐ One primary launch goal with a number (for example, qualified signups or demo requests) and one secondary goal.
- ☐ Launch owner named, with a run-of-show document listing every task, owner and time.
- ☐ Decide the press strategy: one exclusive, a small embargo group, or open announcement.

ASSETS

- ☐ Press kit live (see the Press Kit and Launch PR Template): boilerplate, fact sheet, founder bios, logos, product screenshots, headshots.
- ☐ Announcement blog post, press release and an external FAQ drafted and approved.
- ☐ 60 to 90 second demo video plus 3 to 5 product screenshots or GIFs.
- ☐ Launch landing page with one call to action, tested end to end on mobile, with tracking verified.
- ☐ 3 quotable testimonials from beta users or design partners, approved in writing.
- ☐ Product Hunt assets: tagline, description, gallery images, first comment from the maker.
- ☐ Show HN post drafted if developers are part of your audience.

AUDIENCE

- ☐ Waitlist or beta list open with a concrete reason to join early (access, pricing, feature input).
- ☐ 10 to 20 design partners or beta users recruited who will talk publicly.
- ☐ Founder LinkedIn and X profiles updated: headline, banner, featured post, link to the landing page.
- ☐ Founders posting at least 3 times a week for 4 weeks before launch.
- ☐ Community space ready (Discord, Slack or Telegram) with moderators, rules and welcome flow.
- ☐ Media list of 30 to 60 reporters built by beat, with a recent relevant article for each.
- ☐ Investor, partner and advisor amplification asks sent with copy-paste posts and the exact time to share.

OPERATIONS

- ☐ Launch email sequence written: announcement, use case on day 3, proof or customer story on day 7.
- ☐ Signup and onboarding flow load-tested.

- ☐ Support inbox and status page staffed for launch week.
- ☐ Incident one-pager: who speaks, what you say, and where you post if the site goes down or a security question goes viral.

PHASE 3

Launch week

Run it like an operation. One war-room channel, one owner per channel, a clock everyone works from.

DAY 0

- ☐ Publish the announcement and release exactly at the embargo time. Not five minutes early.
- ☐ Launch email sent to the full list within the first hour.
- ☐ Founders post on LinkedIn and X with native video or images. On LinkedIn, the link goes in the first comment.
- ☐ Product Hunt goes live at 12:01 a.m. Pacific if you are launching there. A maker replies to every comment.
- ☐ Partners, investors and advisors notified with the live links.
- ☐ Pin the launch post on every owned channel.
- ☐ Signups tracked hourly against the launch goal in the war-room channel.
- ☐ Every reply and comment answered for the first 48 hours.

DAYS 1 TO 5

- ☐ Coverage shared as it lands, and each journalist thanked individually.
- ☐ Day 2: publish a customer story or a concrete use-case post.
- ☐ Day 3: founder AMA in your community, an X Space or a LinkedIn Live.
- ☐ Day 4: follow up with non-responding reporters using a new angle (data, customer, contrarian take). Do not resend the release.
- ☐ Day 5: recap post with the numbers you are comfortable publishing.
- ☐ All coverage collected on a press page. "As seen in" logos only for pieces that actually ran.
- ☐ Retargeting audiences built from launch traffic if paid is in the plan.
- ☐ Launch retro held within 7 days: what moved the goal, what did not, what to repeat.

PHASE 4

First 90 days

DAYS 1 TO 30: TEST

- ☐ 3 channels chosen for testing (use the "pick 3 by stage" page in the Channels Playbook).
- ☐ Test budget and kill criteria written for each channel before spending.
- ☐ 2 cornerstone pages published that answer real buyer questions.
- ☐ Onboarding email sequence triggered by activation, not by signup date.
- ☐ Customer interview cadence: 2 per week, notes in one shared place.
- ☐ Founder posting continues at 3 per week.

DAYS 31 TO 60: DECIDE

- ☐ Each channel test reviewed against its kill criteria: cut, keep testing, or scale.
- ☐ First data or research asset published (anonymised usage data, a survey, an on-chain or threat analysis).
- ☐ 2 to 4 earned media pieces, bylines or podcast appearances secured.
- ☐ Referral ask placed at the activation moment in product.
- ☐ Comparison pages published against your top 2 alternatives, factual and fair.
- ☐ First case study published with a named customer.

DAYS 61 TO 90: SYSTEMISE

- ☐ What works documented in a one-page playbook per channel.
- ☐ Contract or hire for the channel that is working, not the one you wish was working.
- ☐ Next-quarter targets set from actual CAC and conversion rates, not benchmarks.
- ☐ Positioning reviewed against win/loss notes. Homepage copy refreshed with customer language.
- ☐ Second launch moment scheduled (feature, integration, partnership or data report).
- ☐ Board or investor update includes marketing learnings, not just numbers.

PHASE 5

Always-on

EVERY WEEK

- ☐ Review the dashboard: traffic, signups, activation, pipeline, blended CAC.
- ☐ 3 founder posts, and 20 thoughtful replies to posts in your niche.
- ☐ Publish one long-form piece or substantially update an existing page.
- ☐ Pitch at least 2 reporters, newsletters or podcasts with a specific angle.

EVERY MONTH

- ☐ Product update email and public changelog entry.
- ☐ Ask ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini and Claude 10 buyer questions. Log whether you are cited (see the GEO Checklist).
- ☐ Refresh your top 5 pages by traffic: facts, dates, screenshots, internal links.
- ☐ Reallocate spend between channels based on cost per qualified outcome.
- ☐ Review DMARC reports and Postmaster spam rate.

EVERY QUARTER

- ☐ Messaging refresh from sales-call notes and 5 win/loss interviews.
- ☐ One planned news moment.
- ☐ Tool audit: cancel unused subscriptions and seats.
- ☐ Press kit, boilerplate and founder bios updated.
- ☐ Budget re-plan using the Marketing Budget Template.

SUMMARY

The 20 channels at a glance

Every channel below is covered in depth in the **20 Marketing Channels Playbook**. Cost and timing are operator estimates for an early-stage B2B or Web3 company; your market will move them.

#	CHANNEL	MAIN JOB	COST TO START	FIRST SIGNAL
1	SEO	Capture existing search demand	Low cash, high time	3 to 6 months
2	GEO / AI search	Get cited in AI answers	Low cash, high time	1 to 3 months
3	Google Ads	Capture high-intent search	\$2K to \$5K test	1 to 2 weeks
4	Meta Ads	Create demand, retarget	\$2K to \$5K test	1 to 2 weeks
5	LinkedIn Ads	Reach exact titles and companies	\$3K to \$8K test	2 to 4 weeks
6	Reddit	Credibility in niche communities	Time, optional ads	2 to 6 weeks
7	X / Twitter	Narrative, crypto and dev reach	Time	2 to 8 weeks
8	LinkedIn organic	Founder-led B2B trust	Time	4 to 8 weeks
9	YouTube	Education and search	Medium	3 to 6 months
10	TikTok / Shorts	Reach and awareness	Low to medium	2 to 8 weeks
11	Email	Convert and retain	Low	Immediate
12	WhatsApp	High-touch nurture in key markets	Low	1 to 4 weeks
13	Communities	Retention, advocacy, support	Time	1 to 3 months
14	Product Hunt and launch sites	Launch spike, backlinks	Low	One day
15	PR / earned media	Credibility, reach, citations	\$5K to \$12K/mo retainer or in-house time	4 to 12 weeks
16	Podcasts	Depth with niche audiences	Time	1 to 3 months
17	Influencers / KOLs	Borrowed trust and reach	Varies widely	1 to 4 weeks
18	Partnerships and integrations	Distribution through others	Time, some engineering	2 to 6 months
19	Events and conferences	Pipeline and relationships	\$3K to \$50K+ per event	Event week
20	Referral programs	Turn customers into acquisition	Low plus incentives	1 to 3 months

Rule of three. Run no more than three acquisition channels at once until one of them works. "Works" means a repeatable cost per qualified outcome you can afford, not a good week.

● NEXT STEP

Want a senior operator *on your launch?*

Templates get you organised. Coverage, citations and pipeline come from judgement: which angle a journalist will actually take, which channel deserves the next dollar, and what to cut.

Book a 30-minute teardown. Bring your launch plan, your positioning or your last campaign and leave with a prioritised list of fixes.

Book a 30-minute teardown: shilikajain.com/contact

Six years

PR and go-to-market for Web3, AI and cybersecurity founders.

50+ protocols

Launches, funding rounds and token events supported.

Tier-1 outlets

Forbes, CoinDesk, Cointelegraph, Decrypt, The Block, Blockworks, AI Magazine.

Prefer to self-serve first? Try the free interactive planners, budget calculator and checklist at shilikajain.com/tools. More downloads live at shilikajain.com/resources.

Engagements: fractional PR retainer \$5K to \$12K per month. Launch sprint \$15K to \$40K.